

Siblings

Just as parent-teen relationships change and are tested throughout puberty, so too are teens' relationships with their brothers and sisters—but in different ways.

SEE ALSO

◀ 174–175 Parent-teen relationships

◀ 176–177 Building trust

◀ 178–179 Dealing with conflict

◀ 180–181 Difficult events

Having siblings

Siblings play different roles in each others' lives—they are friends one minute, adversaries the next. This role-play and role-switching allows teens to test relationship boundaries. Having arguments allows teens to learn how to resolve conflict, while heated discussions teach siblings how to debate, compromise, and respect different opinions—even if they don't agree with them. When they confide in each other, they learn the value of friendship and a trusting relationship.



△ Hanging out together

Sibling relationships can form the template for future relationships, and also help to shape valuable social skills.

Birth order

Brothers and sisters share a family, and yet can be opposites in personality and behavior. Where a sibling sits in the birth order can influence and shape their character traits.

Oldest child

The first-born leads the way. This can put pressure on them, but it also allows them to explore who they are without comparison to another sibling in their early years.



Middle child

The middle child often has to be flexible to the needs of others. They tend to be peacemakers.



Youngest child

The baby of the house may have to fight to be heard, but they typically have more freedom and less responsibility.



Resolving arguments

When arguments occur, it can be hard for siblings not to lash out, but learning to resolve difficult situations is a very useful skill to have.

It can be hard for parents not to get involved, but giving teens the time and space to work things out themselves will help them to develop essential relationship skills. Parents shouldn't take sides, but instead praise efforts at resolution. However, if things turn violent, intervention may be necessary to separate siblings until they calm down.

TEEN HINTS

Keeping the peace

- Remember that the issue you are arguing about is separate from the person you are arguing with. This might help you to see your sibling's point of view.
- You can disagree with someone without being disagreeable. Take a deep breath, stay calm, and think things through before you speak.
- Keep your distance if things become heated, and reconvene once everyone is calm.
- If you feel out of your depth or overwhelmed, emotionally or physically, ask a parent to step in.